



THE DANGERS OF CHANGE APPROVAL PROCESSES

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THE DANGERS OF CHANGE APPROVAL PROCESSES

INTRODUCTION

For many years, organizations have used change approval processes to control the risks involved with making changes to software, systems, and infrastructure. Before updates could be released, they often needed approval from managers or a Change Advisory Board (CAB). The idea behind these approvals was simple: more review would mean fewer mistakes and a more stable environment.

However, as companies have adopted Agile and DevOps practices, many have discovered that long approval chains can actually create more problems than they solve. Instead of reducing risk, too many approvals can slow teams down, delay important fixes, and create unnecessary obstacles. Modern organizations are beginning to rethink whether traditional approval processes are still the best way to manage change.

SLOWER DELIVERY AND MISSED OPPORTUNITIES

One of the biggest problems with change approval processes is the amount of time they add to deployments. Developers may finish their work quickly, but then they have to wait for meetings, signatures, or approval windows before they can release the change.

In today's technology environment, businesses need to move quickly. Customers expect new features, bug fixes, and security updates to be delivered rapidly. When teams spend days or weeks waiting for approvals, organizations risk falling behind competitors who can release updates faster.

This delay can be especially frustrating when the change itself is small and low risk. Something as simple as fixing a typo or updating a configuration setting may end up going through the exact same approval process as a major system upgrade.

BIGGER RELEASES CREATE BIGGER RISKS

Ironically, approval processes that are meant to reduce risk can sometimes increase it. Since approvals often take time, teams may combine many changes into a single large deployment to avoid going through the process repeatedly.

Large releases are much harder to manage than smaller ones. If something breaks after deployment, it becomes difficult to determine which change caused the issue. Fixing the problem usually takes longer, and rolling back the release can be complicated.

DevOps encourages the opposite approach: making small, frequent changes that are easier to test, deploy, and recover from if something goes wrong. Smaller deployments generally create less risk and make troubleshooting much easier.

APPROVAL BOARDS CAN BECOME BOTTLENECKS

Another issue is that approval boards can easily become bottlenecks within an organization. Many approval meetings involve managers, operations teams, security teams, and business leaders. Coordinating schedules between all these groups can slow down the entire process.

This becomes especially problematic during emergencies. If a production system fails or a serious security vulnerability is discovered, organizations need to act immediately. Waiting for the next approval meeting can increase downtime and expose the company to additional risk.

In some cases, the people approving the change may not even fully understand the technical details of the systems involved. The approval then becomes more of a formality than an actual risk assessment.

REDUCED OWNERSHIP BY DEVELOPMENT TEAMS

One of the main goals of DevOps is creating shared responsibility between development and operations teams. Developers are expected to build, test, deploy, and support the applications they create.

Traditional approval processes can sometimes weaken this sense of ownership. When another group is responsible for approving a deployment, teams may begin to rely on the approval process instead of their own testing and quality checks.

An approval signature does not guarantee that a change is safe. In many situations, the developers working directly with the application understand the risks much better than a manager or committee reviewing a document during a short meeting.

NEGATIVE EFFECTS ON INNOVATION

Organizations that require excessive approvals often find that employees become hesitant to suggest improvements or experiment with new ideas. If every change requires multiple approvals and lengthy reviews, people may decide that making improvements simply is not worth the effort.

Innovation depends on the ability to try new ideas, learn from mistakes, and improve continuously. Long approval processes create bureaucracy that can discourage creativity and slow progress.

Companies that are successful with DevOps typically create environments where teams can make changes safely and quickly while still maintaining accountability and quality standards.

A BETTER APPROACH

This does not mean that all approvals should disappear. Certain high-risk changes, such as major infrastructure upgrades or changes involving sensitive customer data, may still require additional review.

The difference is that many modern organizations now use automation instead of manual approvals whenever possible. Automated testing, security scanning, code reviews, and monitoring systems can provide evidence that a change is safe before it reaches production.

This approach allows organizations to maintain control while avoiding unnecessary delays. Teams can move faster while still meeting security and compliance requirements.

CONCLUSION

Although change approval processes were created to protect organizations from failure, they can sometimes have the opposite effect. Long approval chains slow delivery, encourage larger and riskier deployments, create bottlenecks, reduce team ownership, and discourage innovation.

The DevOps model has shown that organizations often achieve better results by focusing on automation, small releases, and shared responsibility rather than relying heavily on manual approvals. While approvals still have a place for certain high-risk situations, modern organizations should carefully evaluate whether their processes are truly reducing risk or simply adding delays.

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